Agasthyamalai (Karnataka - Tamil Nadu - Kerala), Nilgiri (Tamil Nadu - Kerala), Gulf of Mannar (Tamil Nadu) are the BRs notified in Tamil Nadu.

Sacred Groves

A sacred grove or sacred woods are any grove of trees that are of special religious importance to a particular culture. Sacred groves feature in various cultures throughout the world. The examples of sacred groves are Alagar Hills in Tamil Nadu, Khasi and Jaintia Hills in Meghalaya and Aravalli Hills of Rajasthan.

12.7.2 *Ex-Situ* Conservation

It is conservation of selected rare plants/ animals in places outside their natural homes. It includes offsite collections and gene banks.

Offsite Collections

They are live collections of wild and domesticated species in Botanical gardens, Zoological parks, Wildlife safari parks, Arborata (gardens with trees and shrubs). The organisms are well maintained for captive breeding programmes. As a result, many animals which have become extinct in the world continue to be maintained in Zoological Parks. As the number increases in captive breeding, the individuals are selectively released in the wild. In this way the Indian crocodile and gangetic dolphin have been saved from extinction.

Gene Banks

Gene banks are a type of biorepository which preserve genetic materials. Seeds of different genetic strains of commercially important plants can be stored in long periods in seed banks, gametes of threatened species can be preserved in viable and fertile condition for long periods using cryopreservation techniques.

However, it is not economically feasible to conserve all biological wealth and all the ecosystems. The number of species required to be saved from extinction far exceeds the conservation efforts.

Table 12.4 Difference between *Insitu* and *Exsitu* Conservation

***Insitu* Conservation**	***Exsitu* Conservation**
It is the on-site conservation or the conservation of genetic resources in natural populations of plant or animal species.	This is a conservation strategy which involves placing of threatened animals and plants in special care locations for their protection.
It is the process of protecting an endangered plant or animal species in its natural habitat, either by protecting or restoring the habitat itself, or by defending the species from predators.	It helps in recovering populations or preventing their extinction under simulated conditions that closely resemble their natural habitats.
National Parks, Biosphere Reserve, Wild Life Sanctuaries form *insitu* conservation strategies.	Zoological parks and Botanical gardens are common *exsitu* conservation programs.

12.7.3 Role of WWF and CITES

World Wild Fund for Nature (WWF) is an international non-governmental charitable trust founded in 1961, with headquarters at Gland, Vaud, Switzerland. It aims at wildness preservation and the reduction of human impact on the environment. It was formerly named the World Wildlife Fund. The living planet report is being published every two years by WWF since 1998.

The vision of WWF is to conserve nature and reduce the most pressing threats to the diversity of life on Earth by conserving the world's most ecologically important regions, protect and restore species and their habitats, strengthen local communities' ability to conserve the natural resources they depend upon and to ensure that the value of nature is reflected in decision made by individuals, communities, governments and businesses.

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